

Jungle Tales

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Allen Girls Adventures · Library Labyrinth Edition

Chapter 1 — The Village and the Green Gate

This licensed labyrinth edition opens in heat and birdsong, in a village where the smoke from morning fires curled upward and became clouds, or so the children believed.

A girl named Priya asked the oldest storyteller why the jungle remembered everything. The storyteller was carving a wooden comb from a branch that had fallen — never cut, always fallen — and did not look up from her work.

"Because," said the storyteller, adjusting a shawl the color of monsoon clouds, "every leaf is a page. Every river edits the margins. Every root is a sentence that holds the whole paragraph of a hillside in place."

Priya copied this into her notebook using purple ink. She had three notebooks: one for observations, one for questions, and one she left blank because some things needed room before words arrived.

She lived where the forest met the village — close enough to hear monkeys quarreling at breakfast, far enough that her mother made her promise not to wander past the banyan with the red ribbon tied around its trunk. The ribbon had been there since her grandmother's grandmother was small. Nobody remembered who tied it first, which meant everyone was responsible for keeping it there.

Promises in good stories are invitations. Priya kept hers for eight years, two months, and four days, until the morning a message arrived not on paper but on wind: a warm, green-scented gust that turned the pages of her observation notebook to a blank one, and traced a single line of silver condensation across the page that read: Help the river remember its name.

She packed a mango, a second mango just in case, her smallest notebook, a river-stone she had carried since she was five because it fit perfectly in her fist, and courage in sandwich layers — bread of experience, filling of stubbornness, second bread of hope.

Her grandfather's compass pointed not north but inward. She had always wondered what that meant. Today she suspected she would find out.

At the green gate — vines woven by generations as a marker of respect, not fear, with flowers tucked in by hands long still — Priya bowed as she had been taught to bow at thresholds: slowly, eyes open, back straight. The vines parted one finger's width. That was enough.

"Walk with listening," the storyteller called after her.

"I will," Priya said, and stepped into the first sentence of the jungle.

Chapter 2 — The Law of Footprints

The jungle was louder than any classroom and quieter than any library — a contradiction that solved itself once you stopped trying to separate the two. Priya learned the first rule before lunch: take only memories, leave only thanks.

She learned it when a langur the size of a generous child dropped a fig at her feet and watched, patient as an elder, to see what she would do. Priya ate half the fig because hunger is honest and waste is not. She buried the seed in soft earth, firmed it with her heel, and said thank you to the tree the fig had fallen from. The tree rustled approval, shaking three leaves in what she decided was applause.

She was writing down the exact shade of the langur's eyes — amber with black at the rim, like the sunset had moved inside them — when she heard someone whistling badly. The tune was almost right but kept slipping, as if the whistler knew the melody existed but had not yet convinced their breath to agree.

It was a boy her age, Arun, crouched beside a clump of plants she did not recognize, carefully trimming leaves into a cloth pouch his grandmother had embroidered with fish. He gathered herbs every morning for her medicines. He knew the paths by their smell in different weathers. He did not know about the message.

"Rivers have names?" he asked, when she told him.

"Ours did," Priya said. "It forgot, or we forgot it, or both. The message didn't say which direction the forgetting went."

Arun considered this with the same careful attention he gave the herbs. "Maybe that doesn't matter. Maybe remembering is the same action either way."

They traveled together because stories move faster with two voices and two pairs of eyes, because Arun knew which mushrooms wore pretty caps to lie and which berries were safe only after frost, and because Priya could write observations without disturbing the beetles that were always having important conversations just below the narrative.

At dusk they reached a bend in the river where water should have sung against stones — Arun said it used to, his grandmother hummed the rhythm sometimes without knowing why — but now only sighed. Sand had piled where current once carved riddles, and the stones sat silent and dusty, embarrassed to have forgotten their lines.

"The river's name is Kaveri-of-the-Laughing-Stones," Arun whispered. He had not known he remembered this until he said it.

"Then we help her laugh again," Priya said, opening the blank notebook.

Chapter 3 — Clearing the Throat of the River

They did not move sand with shovels. The jungle had an opinion about shortcuts and expressed it with sudden rain and stubborn roots, which was its polite way of saying: find another method.

Instead they held interviews. Priya wrote the questions. Arun translated for creatures who preferred silence to introductions.

The otters had the most useful information, delivered with the confidence of those who know more than they are usually asked. They confessed, somewhat reluctantly, that they had stopped sliding because someone had left

cooking foil and broken glass on the stones last hot season. The game had turned dangerous overnight. Priya organized a cleanup with large leaves folded for gloves and jokes told between trips to keep the mood lighter than the work.

The kingfisher spoke in single precise words from a branch above the muddiest bend: Blockage. Trunk. Here. It indicated with its extraordinary beak a fallen eucalyptus that had rolled across the channel during a storm and been slowly buried by silt, just enough to interrupt the flow without anyone noticing the disaster was gradual.

Arun asked the beavers who lived twenty meters upstream for help. They required credit — a stone with their names, which Priya carved carefully, all four, plus the beaver that had not participated but watched — and snacks, which Arun provided from a bag of peanuts his grandmother had given him for, she said, emergencies. He decided a river's grief qualified.

By late afternoon the trunk was moved, the channel restored, the debris carried to a pile where it would become something else in time.

Priya stood at the bank and read aloud from her notebook, not notes but words she had assembled slowly through the day without knowing that was what she was doing: Kaveri-of-the-Laughing-Stones, we have been listening. We hear what you were. We are working on what you will be. We remember your name and we are not done yet.

Water answered. First a giggle — literal, impossible, completely credible — running over a stone that had been waiting for its joke to land. Then a full laugh that rolled downstream and came back changed into a song.

Fish returned like silver punctuation, commas and full stops and one magnificent long dash.

An elder turtle surfaced at the center of the restored flow, older than the village, younger than the hills, its shell green with history.

"You listened," the turtle said. "That is the law beneath all laws."

Chapter 4 — Stories That Bite and Heal

Not every chapter of the jungle was written in a gentle hand. Priya and Arun found a snare on the third morning — copper wire bent into cruelty and pegged into soil beside a deer trail. It was the kind of thing that ended small stories abruptly. They dismantled it the way you take apart a lie: carefully, so none of the sharpness redirected.

Arun knew how to handle the wire without cutting himself. He had found snares before. The knowing was in his shoulders before his brain named it. Priya hammered a flat stone into the ground beside the trail and scratched words into it with a harder stone: Respect lives here, then in the second language of the nearest trading families, then in a third language she approximated from a phrase-book page she had folded into her observation notebook six months ago on a hunch.

They met a trader two hours later, a man with boots too clean for the path he claimed to have walked. He wanted the shortest way through the sacred grove on the south ridge. He said his cargo was legitimate and his time was money, which Priya recognized as two statements offered as one proof.

She quoted the storyteller: every leaf is a page. He laughed at the poetry. Then the fireflies came, which was unexpected at midday — fireflies preferred dusk — but the jungle had made a point and intended to make it legible. They assembled in the air between Priya and the trader and arranged themselves with patient precision into the letters N and O, which crossed every language on the planet.

The trader left the way he had come. His boots were less clean when he went.

Arun's grandmother arrived at their camp that evening as if she had always planned to be there — which she had, and she had planned it the moment she sent Arun with the herb pouch and the peanuts and not quite enough instructions. She brought soup that tasted of ginger, tamarind, and something she would not name that made difficult things easier to hold.

"You sent them?" Priya asked.

"I sent the need," the old woman said, turning her wooden spoon. "The need was always there. They sent themselves."

That night, around a fire that did not harm moss, they told stories in rounds — some funny and irreverent, some sharp and precise. Each one planted a guardrail in young minds: courage without cruelty, curiosity with care, the difference between secrets kept to protect and secrets kept to control.

Chapter 5 — The Panther's Question

A panther blocked the path on the fourth morning. Not to hunt — it was well-fed and unhurried, which a hunting panther is not. It sat in the center of the path with the stillness of something that had decided it would like a conversation and had the patience to wait for one.

It asked a riddle the labyrinth loves in every edition, across every culture, because some questions are so true they recur:

What grows stronger when shared and never runs out?

Priya knew immediately but held the answer in her chest for a moment because quick answers sometimes crowd out better ones. Then she said: "Stories." She meant it fully, having spent four days watching how a story about a river's name could restore actual water.

Arun had been thinking about the river. He said: "Water, if we protect the source." He meant the care that kept the source clean, not the water itself, which is a more sophisticated answer than it first appears.

The panther blinked — once, slowly, the way large cats express approval without diminishing themselves by saying so aloud. Then it stood, stretched in one magnificent slow curve from nose to tail-tip, and walked sideways into the ferns and was gone. The ferns did not even sway. It had always been a shadow. It had always been there.

The path home opened as if it had been waiting for exactly that exchange. The red ribbon on the banyan had been freshly tied — not re-tied over an old knot but replaced entirely, red cloth bright as a cardinal, still carrying the

warmth of whoever's hands had done it.

Priya ran the last quarter-mile. Her mother scolded exactly as long as love required, then hugged exactly as long as relief required. Her father said nothing because he was the kind of parent who expressed things through standing close.

That evening the storyteller gathered the village on the speaking ground. Priya stood on the smooth flat rock they called the speaking stone, which generations of voices had polished shinier than any chisel could. She told the whole story: the green gate, the langur, Arun, the otters, the snare, the grandmother, the panther. She left nothing out because nothing was shameful and everything was true.

The storyteller asked, "What did you learn?"

Priya said: "The jungle remembers when we remember it. Our job is to keep reading aloud."

Chapter 6 — The Season of Maps

Arun had a project that winter. He was making a map — not an ordinary one that only held paths and distances, but one that held feelings. He marked the place where the river first giggled in a blue that was slightly more cheerful than standard blue. He marked the snare's location in a red with a warning border. He marked the grandmother's camp in warm ochre, which he said was the color of good soup.

Priya argued that maps should be accurate. Arun said his was.

They spent two weeks comparing their different notebooks — her observations, his maps — and found that together they described something neither held alone: the jungle as it actually was, which was both measurable and emotional, documented and alive.

The elder turtle arrived again near the end of winter, walking with the unhurried gravity of something that did not owe time any courtesy. It examined Arun's map for a long while, eyes moving slowly over the ochre and the blue.

"This is a good map," the turtle said finally. "It tells the truth in both directions."

"Both directions?" Priya asked.

"What things are," the turtle said, "and what they mean."

That became the second lesson. The first lesson was listen. The second lesson was: truth needs two directions. You can know everything about a leaf's structure and still miss the leaf entirely if you forget that it means something to the tree.

The kingfisher stopped by at dusk, which was unusual — it was a morning bird by preference. It had a message, delivered in its single-word vocabulary with emphasis provided by wing angle: Stay. It pointed northeast. There was something more that needed knowing.

Priya looked at her observation notebook, her question notebook, and the blank one she carried for things that needed room. The blank one was still blank. Whatever lay northeast would require a new kind of writing.

"Tomorrow?" Arun said.

"Tomorrow," Priya agreed, and they both wrote it in different notebooks in different handwriting that meant the same thing.

Chapter 7 — The Serpent's Cartography

Northeast led through country Arun's maps had marked with a simple notation: older. The trees were different there — wider, taller, roots above ground like the jungle had turned itself partially inside out to show its internal workings. Priya called them root-galleries. Arun called them the library.

They found a snake the length of a grown woman's arm, patterned in green and gold like an illuminated manuscript. It was coiled around a fallen pillar of limestone half-swallowed by moss, and it was not sleeping.

"It's reading," Arun said.

Priya looked more carefully. The snake moved its head slowly across the stone, and where it passed, faint markings became visible in the limestone — not carved by tools but pressed somehow, by years and by water and by the particular chemistry of patience.

The markings were a map. Not of paths, but of time: the river's old channels, the ancient edge of the forest before the village, the location of springs that had been buried by earthquake before anyone's grandmother was born.

"Can we copy it?" Priya asked the snake, because asking was always the first step.

The snake regarded her with steady golden eyes. Then it moved aside exactly enough to let them work, coiling on a higher stone where it could observe. Priya drew. Arun measured scale by counting stones. The work took the whole morning.

When they finished, the snake examined their copy. It flicked its tongue twice — approval or confirmation or both.

"Thank you," Priya said, and meant it with full attention.

The snake led them a short distance further to a spring no one in the village knew existed: clear water rising from limestone, cold in a way that was ancient and clean. They drank. They drew the spring on the copy map. Arun marked it in the particular blue he had decided meant good surprise.

On the walk back, Priya noticed her observation notebook was nearly full. She had one blank page in the middle she had skipped because the page before it had bled through. She used it now to write a rule she was fairly certain was true: the jungle reveals itself gradually to prove you are ready, not because it is secretive.

Arun read it over her shoulder and added one word: usually.

Chapter 8 — The Monsoon Council

The monsoon arrived on a Tuesday, which surprised no one but still managed to startle everyone. It came in three waves: first the smell of wet stone, then the first fat drops that hit the dust and made small craters, then the full curtain of water that made all other sound distant and gentle.

The jungle changed register in monsoon. Colors deepened. Paths became streams. Streams became rivers' younger siblings. The main river — Kaveri-of-the-Laughing-Stones, now fully named and well-remembered — rose with the confidence of something that had been recognized.

The animals held a council. This was not strange to Priya and Arun. The animals held councils regularly; most humans had simply stopped attending. The invitation arrived through the kingfisher, who appeared at Arun's grandmother's window at dawn carrying a single green leaf folded into a shape that meant come.

The council was held in the root-gallery under the oldest tree in that part of the jungle. Attendees: the elder turtle, the panther (observing from above, technically not attending but obviously present), three otters, two beavers, a pair of elephants who had come a considerable distance and were accorded appropriate respect, and various smaller creatures arranged by height on the surrounding roots.

The agenda was water. Specifically, the spring Priya and Arun had mapped, which connected underground to three other springs and ultimately to Kaveri's source. Someone upstream had begun digging that would cut the connection.

Priya asked: what could two children do?

The elder turtle said: write it down. Writing is slower than digging but lasts considerably longer.

Arun's grandmother, who had also been invited and was not at all surprised, explained the underground water system to the village council using Arun's maps and Priya's notes. The village council wrote a letter to the upstream district, which led to a visit from a water engineer who confirmed everything with instruments that measured what the animals had known all along.

The digging stopped. The springs remained connected. Kaveri continued laughing.

The elephant matriarch, before departing, stood near Priya for a long moment and breathed out, which is how elephants express that something has weight and has been noted. Priya stood very still and breathed back.

"You can say anything in silence," Arun said afterward, "if you mean it completely."

Chapter 9 — The Day the Forest Spoke First

There was a morning when Priya arrived at the green gate and found it already open. Not parted — open, fully, both curtains of vine pulled back as if the jungle had been waiting and had grown impatient. This had never

happened. The gate opened for you; you did not arrive to find it open for someone else.

Except the someone it was open for was Priya. The jungle had developed an opinion about when she needed inviting rather than tested.

She went in alone because Arun was visiting cousins and the forest had specific timing. The jungle in late morning after three days of sun was a different color entirely — greens so many and varied that the word green seemed like a first draft of a language that had since become much richer.

She walked for two hours, following no path in particular, guided by the particular quality of light that in good stories and good jungles functions as an arrow. She arrived at a clearing she had never seen, though she had walked this section many times.

In the center: a tree that had been struck by lightning and survived. Half its canopy was gone, and in its place a cascade of ferns and climbing plants had colonized the wound, creating something new from the damage. Small birds lived in the ferns. A pair of bees worked the flowers. The tree itself was broader than three Priyas with arms outstretched.

She did not know what she was supposed to do.

She opened the blank notebook.

After a very long time of listening and not writing, she wrote: I don't know what this means yet. But I'm staying until I do.

She stayed all day. By evening she had filled eleven pages — not explanation but observation, not conclusions but evidence. The damaged tree was not a tragedy. It was a forest's way of writing in the third direction the turtle had not named: not what things are, not what they mean, but what they become.

She ran home at dusk, arriving breathless, and found the storyteller on her front step.

"You were there?" Priya asked.

"I am always there," the storyteller said, which was maddening and completely accurate.

Chapter 10 — Medicines and Mysteries

Arun's grandmother asked Priya one question: can you help me write what I know before I forget how to say it?

It was not that the grandmother was forgetting. She was the sharpest person Priya had ever met. It was that knowledge passed only by voice had a fragility that knowledge written down did not. Not better — the voice held things writing lost — but differently durable.

They spent ten days together that dry month, the grandmother speaking and Priya writing. Arun drew plants. Three hundred and twelve plants used in the village for various purposes, the purpose of each, the season for

finding each, the parts that helped and the parts that did not, the way to prepare each, and at least one story from the grandmother's memory about the first time she encountered each one.

It was not a medical textbook. It was something else: a book about paying attention to the natural world over an entire human lifetime, written in the language of someone who had done exactly that.

Priya asked about a plant she had not seen in the jungle — a small, almost invisible herb that grew in cracks in rocks.

The grandmother described it: four pale leaves, stem no taller than a thumb joint, smell of something between earth and rain. Found only near the old spring.

The one they had helped protect.

Arun and Priya hiked to the spring the next morning. The herb was there in a crack between two limestone blocks, almost invisible, four pale leaves catching the early light.

"Hello," Priya said, and wrote its description so accurately that Arun's drawing afterward matched it in every particular without him having to look again.

The grandmother, shown the pressed specimen and the description, said: this is the one my teacher called the patient plant. It has been waiting for someone to write it down.

Priya thought about all the things waiting for someone to write them down, and felt the weight of that — not as burden but as invitation, the same feeling as the green gate opening.

Chapter 11 — The Second Gate

A year after her first crossing, Priya returned to the green gate. It looked the same — same vines, same light through canopy, same red ribbon on the nearby banyan — but she had changed enough that it looked different.

Arun came with her. He had been once more himself in the intervening months and was no longer startled by anything the jungle said. This made him more useful as a companion and slightly less funny as a conversation partner. The grandmother said that was the trade you made.

They had come for a specific reason: to follow the river from its laughing point all the way to its source, which the snake's map had indicated was further northeast than anyone in the village had walked. The monsoon council had suggested someone should know the source personally, not just by description.

The walk was four days. Arun's maps were correct at every turn. The jungle became progressively quieter and larger as they moved northeast, as if the oldest part of any place is also the most composed.

On the third evening they camped near a cascade that fed into a pool so clear and still it showed the sky below the water, which produced the sensation of standing above clouds. Small fish moved through the inverted sky.

On the fourth morning they found the source.

It was not dramatic in the visual sense — no waterfall, no mysterious shrine, no ancient ruins (though there were some carved stones nearby that Priya photographed for study later). It was a place where water came up from the ground through limestone without rushing, a slow reliable emergence that had been happening since before the village existed. Grass grew at the rim. A single large stone stood to one side, and the stone was warm in a way that stones near running water often are.

Priya put her hand in the source water. Cold, exact, certain.

She wrote in the blank notebook: This is where stories start. Before words. Before the first sentence. Just the fact of it, rising.

Arun added his coordinates to the map in careful numbers.

They sat together for an hour, saying nothing, because some places have already said everything and good visitors know when to listen.

The second gate, they decided on the walk back, was not a place but a moment. It was the moment you understood that learning never ended, and felt glad about it rather than tired.

Chapter 12 — Constellation of Leaves

Years compress in book-time, which is kinder than calendar-time and more honest about what matters. In book-time, Priya became a storyteller with ink-stained fingers and river songs in her pockets before the chapter ended, while still being exactly who she had been at the green gate, just more so.

Children gathered at the gate — the village's children and then the children of families who had heard there was a gate worth gathering at — to hear about otters and kingfishers and the day water laughed again, about the snake with the limestone map, the elephant's exhale, the patient plant in the crack by the spring.

Arun drew maps that included feelings. He had become known for this beyond the village and beyond the valley. He was visited by cartographers who wanted to argue and left having learned something they did not expect. His grandmother said he had always known how to include feelings in things; he had simply found the right form.

The elder turtle still surfaced occasionally at the laughing stones, ate a fig it brought itself, left wisdom of a particular kind: long, slow, and impossible to rush. The panther was seen in the fern country now and then by people who were listening. The kingfisher remained extremely reliable.

The blank notebook was full now, had been full for years, had been followed by several more. What was in it was not poetry or science exactly but something that required both the way the river required both stone and water.

Priya stood on the speaking stone one last time in this story's time, in the long blue evening when the fireflies came out and the jungle hummed at a frequency that meant content.

She said: we are part of the story the jungle tells. Not observers, not visitors, not even exactly students, though we learn. We are the part of the story where the forest passes what it knows to the part of itself that carries it forward. That is what we are for.

The storyteller, old enough now that she rarely stood, stood.

The jungle exhaled.

Close the book. Step outside. Name one tree near you.

That is the jungle remembering you back.

Licensed classics in the Library Labyrinth are told in full for young readers, never emptied of respect. If you loved Priya's walk, place this volume on the return shelf with gratitude. The constellation of readers above the skylight gains one more light — yours.

THE END